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Joe Temperley

Joe Temperley was born in Cowdenbealth, Scotland in 1929. Jazz became his passion and he took advantage of the playing opportunities available in Scotland and England, including a lengthy stint with the Humphrey-Lyttelton Band. He immigrated to the U.S. in 1965 and found a niche for his distinctive baritone sax in the bands of Woody Herman, Buddy Rich, Thad Jones-Mel Lewis and on numerous recordings. Joe replaced Harry Carney in the Ellington Orchestra and provided a sound that seemed irreplaceable. He currently lives in New York City, performs with the Lincoln Center Jazz Orchestra and frequently appears at jazz festivals and parties across the country.

Joe was interviewed at the Jerome Jazz Party in Aspen, Colorado on October 11, 1997, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in Aspen, Colorado. It's my pleasure to be talking with Joe Temperley today, saxophonist, baritonist, and sopranoist and all the other ists. Bass clarinetist. We were just talking about the hazards — not hazards — but things you have to deal with being on the road and traveling in planes. Does that get tiring?

JT: It gets really exhausting, yeah. I mean I've had a flight case made for the baritone. I've been using it for the past twenty odd years because I discovered I got into too many arguments with flight attendants and flight stewards and people like that. And it just wasn't worth it. So I got an Anvil case, a really good case, a really beautiful case. And it just goes underneath and it makes life that much easier.

MR: Out of the work you do, how much of it involves going away from your home?

JT: Well I mean I don't travel around per se all the time. Like I've come out here, but I haven't been on the road in two or three months. I do most of my work in New York. I do a lot of freelance work in New York and I work in various different places. I work with Junior Mance and we have a trio and sometimes a quartet. So when I do go traveling, it's very pleasant. I do things like a trip on the Norway or this year we went to the festival in Berne, but it's only like three or four days, it's not a continuous thing. Although next year, the whole of February and March I'm going to be traveling with the Lincoln Center Jazz Orchestra with Wynton Marsalis. So that's going to be a whole big trip for eight weeks.

MR: Quite an operation to move a whole orchestra like that.

JT: Yeah. We have three weeks in the United States and then we have three weeks in Asia and then we come back and do another two weeks in the United States. So it's a big trip.

MR: I didn't know you worked with Junior Mance. He's one of my favorites.

JT: Oh, yeah. I work a lot with Junior Mance. We have a new record coming out in the next couple of weeks on Chiaroscuro that we recorded on the Norway, with Keter Betts on Bass and Jackie Williams on drums, Junior and myself. And it turned out very good you know. They just kept recording us every night and we played I think four, maybe five nights on the boat, and they recorded everything. And now they say they have enough stuff for two CDs. So we'll see. One of them comes out in the next couple of weeks.

MR: Did you happen to play a tune with him called "Harlem Lullaby?"

JT: No. No, I didn't.

MR: Well you ask him about that.

JT: I will. Yeah.

MR: It's a great tune he wrote years ago.

JT: Oh yeah?

MR: It's got a real nice sound to it.

JT: No the only thing we played of Junior's actual compositions is "Jubilation," which of course was recorded by a lot of different people, you know, like Cannonball and Benny Golson and I think Ben Golson made a recent recording of it. And Jessie Davis made a recent recording of it. So Junior really gets a lot of mileage out of "Jubilation."

MR: That's nice to write a tune early in your career that has some life to it like that. Absolutely.

JT: Yeah, he gets a lot of mileage out of that.

MR: Well growing up in Scotland, right, your home town was what?

JT: Cowdenbealth.

MR: I wasn't going to try to pronounce that.

JT: Cowdenbealth is about maybe 20 miles northeast of Edinburgh. It's in Fife actually. It's over the other side of the Forth Bridge. And it's in the Kingdom of Fife. And that's the only County in Scotland that's actually called a Kingdom. So I grew up there, but I left there when I was like 17 or 18, 17 maybe.

MR: What kind of music did you hear as a child?

JT: Well the only kind of music that I vividly remember is dance bands on the radio. You know bands like Henry Hall and Geraldo and those kind of bands. And then when I got a bit older, when I got to be around 14 or 15, I started playing the saxophone when I was 14. And when I was about — first there was no music schools or anything like that so I just had a few lessons locally and then I just had to get on with it myself more or less. I'm still doing that. And the first introduction to jazz actually I had was Cab Calloway's band. It was a saxophone record. On one side was Chu Berry playing "Ghost of a Chance," on the other side was "Willow Weep for Me" with Hilton Jefferson. So I've spoken to Milt

course I remembered some things like Benny Goodman "Sing Sing Sing" but it was a very short time. These were 78s and they were very scarce. You know American jazz was very scarce in Scotland. Still is as a matter of fact.

MR: Did you get a chance to hear any of these artists? Did they ever come to Scotland?

JT: No. Not while I was there. Much later they did. I mean they do now, they travel around quite a bit now. And the thing, I spoke to Conte Candoli last night about this because there was a union ban. The British musicians union didn't allow American musicians to come in to the country to play. So when Conte Candoli came to Ireland with Stan Kenton in 1953, I was working with an English band that also was working in Dublin at the same time. So we got to see the concert. And that band had Lee Konitz and Zoot Sims and Bill Holman and people like that, Conte Candoli, and Frank Rossalino. That was a great band. But that was the first really American jazz orchestra that I ever encountered.

MR: At what point in your early years as a saxophonist did you make a conscious decision that you were going to make a living as a musician?

JT: No it just sort of grew on me I guess. When I first started off in Scotland, I went to work in a nightclub in Glasgow. And that was a traumatic experience for me, even though I was only moving 50 miles from my home town, my accent for instance was completely different from a Glasgow accent. I was a real country bumpkin.

MR: Just 50 miles away?

JT: Well the accents in the British Isles are very regional. You know you can, even in London there's about four or five completely different accents you know. North London is completely different from South London. And I mean you wouldn't really sort of think about that until you actually live there and you can hear the difference. And this, in Scotland, when I went to Glasgow, that was a big traumatic experience for me. And I started playing little bits of jazz and going to jazz clubs and I had a gig in a night club with a five piece band and there was a trumpet player, his name was Jimmy Morgan, and he had come up from London. He'd been living in London for a long time. And I learned a lot of stuff from him, talking about music and talking about playing and this is how you do this and that. I learned a lot. And that's how, in those days, that's how you came to gain knowledge, by listening to other people and actually experiencing it for yourself. Nowadays I teach at the Manhattan School of Music. And it's a whole different thing. The kids today are in danger of maybe of learning too much too fast. And it sort of homogenizes the playing. It tends to make them sound like the same.

MR: Do they have too much knowledge and no place to use it?

JT: Right, yeah. That kind of thing too. But the physicality of the playing doesn't come together with the knowledge that they gain, like the harmonic knowledge and the practice

them. Whereas in the old days we just learned a tune. We didn't know that you had to play this scale for this chord or you know. We learned tunes and we'd learn how to deal with them. You learned the harmony of the song and learn how to deal with it. But it's a whole different thing now.

MR: What kind of tunes were you playing in this club in — was it Edinburgh you said?

JT: In Glasgow, yeah. I don't know. I think like "My Blue Heaven" and "Blue Skies" and you know those kind of standards.

MR: Was there a sense that this music was coming out of America and that we wanted to get our hands on it? That records of it were something to search out for you guys?

JT: Oh yes. It was very important. That was very important to search out records. Because they were very scarce and you didn't see many 78s in those days. So when a new record came, a new record would be maybe Benny Goodman's "Sing Sing Sing" and everybody would have to get a copy of "Sing Sing Sing." You'd have to order it, it would have to come from London or somewhere, you know, it was a whole big operation. Nowadays you have everything on hand. The whole history of jazz is right there before you.

MR: In one CD collection.

JT: Right, yes. I mean I think of myself, I have maybe about 60 or 70 Duke Ellington CDs. In those days, the only Duke Ellington song I probably knew would be maybe "Take the A Train" or something.

MR: Interesting that you ended up playing with them. But we'll get to that. You played with Humphrey Lyttelton? Was he one of the well known jazz people in the United Kingdom?

JT: Yeah. Humphrey Lyttelton, he started off in the traditional jazz field you know, with banjos and stuff like that. And then gradually, over a period of time, gradually, by listening, his hero was always Louis Armstrong and Sidney Bechet. But then he became, his taste became more catholic and he started developing a liking for people like Roy Eldridge and Buck Clayton, and then Buck Clayton became a big friend. You know Buck Clayton used to come over and do a lot of tours with us. Buck Clayton and Jimmy Rushing or Buck Clayton and Big Joe Turner, and we used to do tours on the continent and this was in the 50s. And Humphrey was a very sort of, he's a tremendously educated man. He went to Eton and I mean he's a real scholar. And for him to make a career of being a jazz musician is sort of off the wall in England, in English high society and stuff.

MR: He should be teaching in a university somewhere.

JT: Yeah, well no, he should be a member of Parliament there, or in the Army, a Colonel in the Guards or something.

MR: Well when was the first trip to the United States?

JT: The first trip was with Humphrey's band in 1959. We came with the Newport Jazz Tour

was another English group that was co-led by Alan Ganley and Ronnie Ross, and then there was American groups like George Shearing with a brass section. He had just made a record with a brass section. And there was George Shearing and Cannonball Adderley and Nat with their group, and also Thelonious Monk, which was a big eye opener for me, to actually be on a tour with the Thelonious Monk Quartet and be able to see Thelonious Monk working every night and hear Charlie Rouse's approach to playing and Thelonious playing the piano. That was really a big eye opener for me. And coming to New York City of course, I spent a lot of time going down to the Five Spot and at that time, Benny Golson was working at the Five Spot with Curtis Fuller and I used to go there a lot. And of course being on tour with Cannonball Adderley and being on tour with Thelonious Monk, when it actually came time to leave New York I just said to the drummer in the band, I said this place is just something that I must come back to. I have to come back to New York. And I did. Six years later I came back to New York. And if I'd known what I was getting into I probably wouldn't have done it. But I came back, and I didn't really know anybody, I didn't have a job, but six months later I started working with Woody Herman's band through Jake Hanna and Nat Pierce got me on Woody Herman's band and I just sort of went from there.

MR: Did you have to wait to get into the union?

JT: Yes. It took six months to get into the union, Local 802. It doesn't take that, it takes six minutes now, or even six seconds. They're dying to get people in the union.

MR: They need the dues.

JT: Oh, yes. But at that time it was like a six month wait. So I waited it out.

MR: What did you do during those six months?

JT: I worked in Korvettes, selling audio equipment. And that was an experience too of course. All of a sudden you know I went from playing every night, playing my saxophone and all that, all of a sudden I'm working in a retail store. But it served its purpose.

MR: That's right. It puts things in perspective for you.

JT: Yes, absolutely, yes. And living in New York I started going out to hear people and became friendly with people like Pepper Adams and Cecil Payne and different people. And then I spent maybe 18 months with Woody's band. But it was very hard then. It was very rigorous. I couldn't deal with all those bus trips.

MR: Constant, huh?

JT: Every day. Ten hours, twelve hours a day. And then playing a gig at the end of it. Phil Woods had a funny remark. He said "When these kids graduate from school, they should be taken and they should all be put in a bus and they should pull the blinds down, and the

out and go into the gym and play a four hour gig, and then get back in the bus and ride for another ten hours, and then see if they want to really be musicians." That was before they get presented with their diploma.

MR: You pass the bus test now you may graduate.

JT: Yeah. It's a different thing nowadays. You don't do that anymore.

MR: Well it's good and bad I suppose because now there's not as many venues for the big bands. Who else was on that herd at the time?

JT: Well the saxophone section was strictly Italian. It was Sal Nestico and Joe Romano and Carmen Leggio.

MR: Some good tenors there.

JT: Oh it was wonderful. It was really wonderful. And it was a good band. And Woody was going through some bad times because things were rough on the road and Woody was having to deal with income tax problems and some nights he would just say, "I'll see you all later" and he would dodge out the back because he had this thing about spotting people. He could spot an IRS man coming in the door, and he'd be out the back door and gone.

MR: Oh that's too bad.

JT: But Woody was a great experience.

MR: Well you sat in a number of good big band sections.

JT: Oh yes.

MR: Buddy Rich and—

JT: I didn't work with Buddy all the time. I only seemed to work with Buddy when he was looking for a baritone player. But I would never do that, I would never go out with Buddy's band. Buddy was too strict for me. I couldn't deal with that.

MR: He was a task master, to put it nicely.

JT: Yeah. Well I mean we used to play a set and then he'd get everybody in the band room and tell everybody how rotten they all were and how they couldn't play. And you had to deal with all these lectures all the time.

MR: He really built up the morale, huh?

JT: But he had some good bands.

MR: Yeah? Good records.

JT: Yeah he had some good bands.

MR: How about the thing with Thad Jones and Mel Lewis?

JT: Well that came about when I used to sub sometimes for Pepper. And around, I think it was around '68, somewhere around there, '68 or '69, Pepper's mother got very sick. And he decided that he wanted to go back to Detroit to take care of her, which I thought was a

well known and world renown, and for him to just pick up and go back to Detroit, it was a wonderful thing to do. Anyway, I subbed for Pepper in the Thad Jones band, and the subbing consisted of about maybe two and a half or three years before he finally came back. So I had a lot of great experience, and I made a wonderful record with that band called "Central Park North," which I still listen to that record, it was a great band, it was a wonderful band.

MR: Thad wrote some really innovative charts.

JT: Oh yeah. It was a great thing about Thad's writing though, it was always so beautifully melodic. You could take it down, when we used to be rehearsing with the saxophone section, you could slow it down and play every part real slow and it was a beautiful melodic part. He was really a genius. And it was a great experience too.

MR: And you did the Monday nights at the Vanguard.

JT: At the Vanguard. Every Monday. And you used to see — all kinds of people used to come in there: Don Byas, Ray Nance, Paul Gonzalves, a whole lot of people used to come in on Monday nights. It used to be a wonderful experience.

MR: Who were your influences—

JT: But the thing about — I must tell you this. When I actually played with the Thad Jones and Mel Lewis Band, I was so over-awed by the feeling of playing in that band and I couldn't play for looking at everybody. You know looking at Snooky Young and Jimmy Nottingham, and Mel Lewis and Richard Davis and Jerome Richardson and Joe Farrell and all these people that were in the band. It was just a numbing experience for me. I would like to do it now you know. I would like to really do that again now.

MR: That was quite a roster of — everyone was a soloist.

JT: The saxophone section was Jerome Richardson and Jerry Dodgion and Joe Farrell and Eddie Daniels and myself. It was amazing.

MR: That's great. 1974 was a pretty significant year for the Ellington—

JT: Yes. That's when I went with the Ellington band, yes. That came about with John Gensel, the pastor at the Lutheran Church on 54th Street and Lexington Avenue. He was the Shepherd of the Night Flocks, he was the pastor for the jazz community, John Gensel. He asked me to play at Harry Carney's funeral. So I played "Sophisticated Lady" at Harry's funeral. Harry was a good friend of mine too. And that's how that came about. A few weeks later I was in the band.

MR: How did you meet Harry?

JT: I met him in England when the band used to come. Humphrey, when the Ellington band used to come to England, Humphrey used to buy tickets for everybody in the band. And we used to go, the first time the Ellington band came to England, they did maybe 26

around, all over the place. And every night we'd walk in and see everybody, and they'd say, "Oh you guys are here again." You know they couldn't figure out why we were at the concerts all the time. But it was such — Duke Ellington, that was such a thing, to go and watch that band and see all those people that were in the band.

MR: They had the whole — that was the prime: Hodges and Harry—

JT: Harry and Paul and Jimmy Hamilton. It was amazing.

MR: Were they on every night, from one night to the next? Can you remember that?

JT: Well yeah. No, no they weren't on every night. I mean sometimes they sounded like a high school band. And then they could be sounding terrible and 10 or 15 minutes later, they sounded like something you've never heard in your life before. They were just absolute — the way they could turn it on — maybe if they saw somebody walking in or if somebody came in to see them — all of a sudden the band would be transformed into something entirely different. Because you know that band traveled all the time. They were tired.

MR: Years and years on the road.

JT: It was an amazing band. And it still is, it's still the premier jazz orchestra of all times, in my opinion.

MR: So was Mercer leading the band after '74?

JT: Yes. Mercer became the band leader. And I got along pretty well with Mercer. You know Mercer was a very nice man. It was just, I couldn't stay in the band because I couldn't do all that traveling. I just had enough of traveling. Constant bus riding and traveling around all the time, I just had enough of it.

MR: I wonder how people do that for years and years. I mean think of Harry Carney, some 30 years.

JT: Well the band was different then. I mean they were on a mission. The band was entirely different. Mercer's band wasn't like that at all. Half the people in the band didn't know anything about Duke Ellington. So it was a different thing. And then when the Ellington band was in its prime, of course, the musicians couldn't work in the studios in New York, because of the racial thing. So that's why the Basie band was together all the time and that's why the Ellington band was together. And that's why the Basie band and the Ellington band were so much better than all the other bands. Because they had constant personnel. The other bands, you came in, you made a name, stayed four, five, six months and then you went to CBS or NBC and that was it. That was your career.

MR: So for the black musicians playing with Ellington or Basie was the height.

JT: That was a career in itself. That was as good as you could get. Of course that made the band great.

MR: The studio scene in New York, what kinds of situations did you find yourself in, doing studio work? Did you do jingle work and all that kind of stuff?

JT: Yeah.

MR: You're still doing that.

JT: I'm still doing that. But I never did that on a full time basis. I just did odd jingles, I do jingles, but just now and again. It's not a steady thing. I do some record dates for different people, but it's just people that request me, that want me, want ME to do the record dates, rather than some contractor calling up.

MR: Some other baritone player.

JT: Yeah. Just want a baritone player. That tends to be a small clique of people that play all the instruments you know. If they want a baritone player they'll get an alto player and he'll come in and play the baritone and that's how that works. So I don't do a full time job. But I wouldn't want to really do that all the time.

MR: Of your contemporaries on the instrument these days, who do you feel are up there in the top league? I know that you're fond of Ernie Caceres in his day.

JT: Oh yeah, Ernie Caceres, and of course Harry Carney was always my idol. I really thought Harry Carney was the epitome of the sound of the baritone. I like other people. I like Cecil Payne, I'm very fond of Cecil Payne, and he's a very good personal friend of mine. But I mean before that I was attracted to his playing tremendously, especially when he was at the height of his powers in the 50s and early 60s. Cecil's approach to the baritone was just wonderful. But I like other people. I like Pepper a lot and I like Nick Brignola and Ronnie Cuber and Gary Smulyan and people like that playing today. And of course I loved Gerry Mulligan. Gerry was a good friend of mine too, and I've actually done some concerts, memorial concerts. We did one with the Lincoln Center Band at Lincoln Center. I went to Vienna and did one with Bob Brookmeyer and Lee Konitz. So that's interesting too. We might do some more of that I don't know.

MR: But you're also playing the soprano quite a bit.

JT: Oh yes. I've played the soprano a long time. But you know I play the tenor quite a bit. I like to play the tenor. But I don't play the tenor as much as I would like to but I play in school. I have two or three tenor students in school so I get to play the tenor. And then I do some gigs and things, odd things, and sometimes with the Lincoln Center band I'm sort of, like sometimes I play the tenor in different situations, sometimes I play the soprano, and at first I played the baritone and bass clarinet. So I'm kind of a utility man there as well as being the baritone player there. Like in this upcoming Sidney Bechet concert I'm going to be playing the soprano, which I'm looking forward to.

MR: In that situation, are you trying to emulate him as close as possible?

JT: No. Not at all. Wynton doesn't encourage that. He likes, like we play Ellington music, he likes you to play your own idea of what you think it should be, rather than just play the solos note for note. Then I don't think it's a fair reproduction because you can't play like that. I can't sound like Harry Carney. And somebody else can't sound like Cootie Williams, and somebody else can't sound like Paul Gonsalves. You can't do it.

MR: We can listen to their records if we want to hear them.

JT: Of course. Yeah. And you can play your own way in that particular feeling but you can't impersonate them. I don't think that's a good thing.

MR: What's your outlook on the state of jazz these days?

JT: Well it's kind of fragmented, the jazz situation. And I think, for instance, I think all the young, the supposed young lions, they should be playing with each other, instead of all having their own bands. When things were at the height, you know, the Miles Davis Sextet and the Miles Davis Quintet, it was Miles Davis and Coltrane, and Philly Joe and Red Garland and Paul Chambers. But nowadays, every one of those people would have their own band. And I don't think that's really a good thing. I think all these young people should be playing with each other and develop. Because that's the only way they can develop. I think that's one aspect of it. And I think the jazz situation is very healthy and we see a lot of kids at Lincoln Center, a lot of young people come to our rehearsals and they get involved, and Wynton encourages them to play, and when we go out and tour he goes to all the different schools. Sometimes we go with him, sometimes he goes by himself. But he does encourage young people to play instruments, play jazz, and to play blues and swing. And I think it's very important too to play blues and swing.

MR: Well blues has got to be a part of the jazz music. And I was interested in hearing the second set last night, that they opened up with a blues tune. And it was really nice, just to hear some wailing.

JT: You know I mean I think a lot of the trouble today is that the playing becomes too homogenized. Too many people sound alike. But you know I'm very interested in golf, and that's what's happening with golf too, because people go to golf school and they all come out with the same swing and they all look the same and they all play the same, they all play the same way. And for instance in the old days you could tell a musician by his vibrato. Ben Webster had a different vibrato completely to Lester Young or Coleman Hawkins or Don Byas or Lucky Thompson. Each one had an individual sound. You could tell. Two notes from Zoot Sims and you know that was Zoot. Two notes from Stan Getz and you knew that was Stan and it couldn't be anybody else. That was who they were. That doesn't happen anymore. You could identify Roy Eldridge. Last night I was sitting in one of the intermissions and they played a record of Prez. And I was just reminiscing

style was so personal. Playing out the side of his mouth and play all those beautiful things that he used to play, but it was so personal and so real. And that band, with Roy Eldridge and Prez and Vic Dickinson, sounded amazing. And they were three completely identifiable people. Conte Candoli said, "that can only be Little Jazz."

MR: That can only be what?

JT: "Little Jazz." Roy Eldridge.

MR: As you say, they were all giants but they were all playing together.

JT: Yes. And I think that made the music better too. They weren't playing from some five star hotel with a corporate account and all that kind of stuff. It was different.

MR: What was your favorite recent recording of yours? I know you did a "Concerto for Joe," not your most recent though.

JT: But it was done in too much of a hurry to be my favorite. I liked the one I did with Dave McKenna, that turned out good.

MR: The duet.

JT: The duet, yeah. I love playing with Dave McKenna. I mean that's another one who sets a distinctive style. Nobody can play that rhythmic pulse like he can. That's another thing that's a bygone thing. But you know I'm always looking, the next record, maybe the next record will be the one. I don't tend to listen to the records I've made particularly. I hear it a couple of times and I say oh yeah, okay. I could have done this or I could have done that or this could have been better. So it always can be better. And I feel that if you feel like that it always will be better. I think it's important to just keep forging ahead.

MR: Yeah. To not do one recording and think that that's the best you can do.

JT: Well no.

MR: Well I have a photo here. I wonder if you recall this particular—

JT: Oh, yeah. That was the Chiaroscuro session with Buck Clayton. Zoot and I were playing ping pong that day. He was a good friend. He was a beautiful musician too.

MR: I think Milt Hinton probably took that. It's out of the book.

JT: He did, yes.

MR: Is that possible to zoom in on that photo?

JT: That was a great saxophone section too, that was like Budd Johnson and Earle Warren and Zoot and myself.

MR: Wow. Earle Warren.

JT: Yeah Earle Warren. Smiley. Earl Warren had one of the best golf swings I ever saw in my life. Oh it was beautiful. Wonderful golfer. And one of the best swings I ever saw.

MR: Gee there's a lot of musicians who love golf.

JT: Oh yeah. Well golf is very inventive too you know. But I used to play a lot of golf with

golf course. But that particular session for Buck, that Earl "Fatha" Hines was on piano and Gus Johnson on drums and Milt Hinton and Joe Newman and Urbie Green and Doc Cheatham. It was like a dream you know. I miss Buck Clayton because he was a real dear friend of mine. In fact I'm now the leader of the Buck Clayton band. We've been doing some things in New York with Buck's music and I've sort of been designated to be the leader. So it's quite exciting to go out and play Buck's music.

MR: Who's taking the trumpet part in that?

JT: Well we have different people. We have Byron Stripling and Randy Sandke and Riley Mullins, a young fellow. And different people do it. We have Britt Woodman, Art Baron, Jerry Dodgion and Harry Allen. It's quite exciting.

MR: Amazing circle of musicians to choose from.

JT: Oh yeah, right. Dick Katz plays piano and sometimes we have Joe Ascione or Akira Tana played a couple of times with us. And Dennis Irwin played with us a couple of weeks ago. So we have a big roster of musicians to draw on. And they're all familiar with the music and familiar with the band and they've all played on the band from time to time.

MR: What's the scene like in New York City right now for you as far as gigging right in the city? I know you have the Lincoln Center.

JT: I'm busier now that I've ever been.

MR: Yeah?

JT: Yeah. Like next week I'm working at the Knickerbocker and the week after I'm working at Zinno's. I do Zinno's quite a bit with Junior. And we have a couple of concerts at Lincoln Center, an Ellington concert and then we have a benefit concert with Oscar Peterson, and then a Sidney Bechet concert. And I took on some things to work at Cafe Carlyle with Bobby Short. So I'm really busy until the end of the year, until the middle of January. And then I go on this tour, we start rehearsing for this tour, which takes me up until the end of March. And then I'm going to England and Scotland.

MR: I was just going to ask if you ever have occasion to get back to Scotland.

JT: Yeah. I was there a year ago, a year past February. I have a high school band there. We started off doing a seminar in the summertime. We started off with like 15 kids. And now there's 75 kids and there's three different bands. There's a band from like 8 years old to 11, and there's another band from 11 to 14, and another band from 14 to 16 or 17. So now it's grown and in fact, we're trying to arrange for them to come to Lincoln Center. Because at Lincoln Center we have a high school competition — an Ellington competition. It started off with seven states. In fact it started off with just the three states around New York: New York, New Jersey and Connecticut. Then it grew to seven states. Now it's the whole eastern part of the United States, all the way to the Mississippi. So

too. I'll go out and do some clinics with that, and a couple of years ago I did some of the judging, last year I was a mentor which means you go up and play with the school bands and you sort of prime them for the competition. So it's very interesting to do things like that. So I keep busy all the time.

MR: And when you leave here, your very next thing you said—

JT: The Knickerbocker.

MR: The Knickerbocker.

JT: And of course I have all my teaching to do too. I have to give 6 students 14 lessons in a semester. That's a lot.

MR: That must be hard to juggle too.

JT: Yeah, I have to juggle it. That's exactly what I have to do is juggle it. But that's very interesting. I really like doing that. And I learn just as much from them as they do from me. So it's really interesting to do that.

MR: Yeah. Plus they get to see what a professional has to deal with in the real world of music.

JT: Yeah. And I play with them all the time. I play duets with them and I play with them. We play different songs and different kinds of blues and go through different chord sequences and things like that. And it's interesting to try and get the kids motivated into doing that. Like for instance, one kid came to me and said, "Oh I've just recorded a CD." I said, "Oh that's nice." I said, "What kind of tunes did you play?" He said, "Oh I played Giant Steps." So I said, "How can you play "Giant Steps" when you can't play the blues? How could you tackle "Giant Steps?" I don't know, but these kids have a lot of chutzpah, you know what I mean? He probably played the melody of "Giant Steps" but God knows what he played after that.

MR: I can't imagine.

JT: So it's very interesting.

MR: That's a good one, yeah. You'd better do "Giant Steps" on your next record to show him how it's done.

JT: Oh, yeah. I don't know if I could tackle that because it took John Coltrane two years to learn how to play that. You don't just do that in five minutes.

MR: Well I've enjoyed talking with you today.

JT: Oh it's been a pleasure, yeah.

MR: And I wish you all the best.

JT: Thank you.

MR: And I hope to hear your soprano sax again tonight.

JT: Oh, yeah, I'm going to play tonight, yeah. I'm going to play with Ralph tonight. The first set tonight is with Ralph, so I love to play the soprano with Ralph. I'm going to surprise

MR: I'm just fascinated by watching the interaction that goes on stage, especially when you're doing, in the middle of a tune, and someone's soloing, and one of the horn players will start a background riff. Like last night, I can't even remember what set it was, but someone set up a two bar riff and the second time the riff came around everybody had it.

JT: Oh yeah.

MR: There's no like fumbling or trying to hear. It's almost like it was rehearsed but I don't think it was.

JT: Oh no. But I mean there's a lot of patterns that you can play. And like for instance Conte Candoli came up with a great one last night and we just started — Dan Barrett and I just jumped on it right away, and it made it sound so good. And all he said was "Woody Herman," you know?

MR: I wrote a riff down I heard last night. It was like [scats].

JT: Oh that's Norris that does all those kind of things. Norris Turney, yeah. He does all those kind of riffs, yeah.

MR: Well it's fun to watch as well as listen.

JT: Oh it's a pleasure, yeah.

MR: Well good luck to you, and thanks for your time today.

JT: Thank you very much.